more and more of the time citizens and the government itself turned to the military for solutions.

CIVIL STRIFE IN POSTINDEPENDENT BURMA

Endemic conflict between the majority Burman government and ethnic minorities threatened the political progress of Burma. The country has a complicated cultural and linguistic structure. Two-thirds of Burma's 52 million people are Burman, while the rest is made up of multiple ethnic minorities. The ethnic groups are distinguished in terms of language, culture, and religion.

In the early years of the Myanmar republic multiple insurrections occurred, stifling the development of the nation state. Insurgencies emerged from both political and ethnic factions. The first groups to launch insurrections included the Karen, Mon, and Arakanese groups. Within five years the Shan and Kachin armies launched further insurrections. Finally, the Chin-armed rebellion has been a constant problem for state authorities.

The most significant problem facing the Burmese state was the civil war between the communist movement and the newly formed state of Myanmar led by U Nu. The communist movement in Myanmar split into two factions. The moderate and larger “White Flags,” or Burmese Communist Party (BCP), were led by Than Tun, while the smaller and more radical “Red Flags,” or CPB, were led by Thakin Soe.

The issue of weapons proliferation exacerbated the insurgency problem in Burma. Most groups had weapons that were left over from the British withdrawal in the early 1940s or the Japanese departure in 1945. Furthermore, the Burmese resistance had an ample supply of arms from the allies during the latter stages of the conflict.

The British decision to rule the CPB illegal prior to granting Burma independence was the actual spark that started the insurrection, according to Charney (61). Both communist movements appealed to the peasantry with popular platforms of land redistribution and poverty alleviation. U Nu's regime considered bringing the more moderate “White Flags” into the government fold but ultimately the lack of trust between the parties doomed any potential deal. Within the first year of independence, U Nu was